

Remixed Ubuntu for the netbooks

Ubuntu Netbook Remix joins Moblin as a lightweight, optimised solution for Atom-based netbooks, while offering the usual stability and friendliness of the Ubuntu family.

In this short review, we'll look at what Ubuntu Netbook Remix (UNR) has to offer. From wireless to multimedia, it's Ubuntu all over. The major difference is in the desktop layout and the performance on low-end modern processors.

Get UNR

UNR is available for download from the official Ubuntu website. However, getting UNR ready for use is slightly different from the typical Linux distribution, so let's spare a few moments and see how you can get UNR booted on your machine.

After you have downloaded the UNR v9.10 ISO file, you will have to copy it, bit-by-bit to a bootable external device. Standard USB thumb drives are ideal for this task. Images can be copied using the *dd* command—or much simpler, by using the USB Starter Disc Creator utility, which can be found in the Ubuntu Live CD. Follow the instructions and you're all set.

The desktop

The UNR desktop has a very unique, interesting look. The choice of colours is Ubuntu, with browns, oranges, and a darker, more sombre scheme than the original. What makes the biggest difference is the layout, which takes some time getting used to. On the left side, there's the GNOME menu, with combined *Applications*, *Places* and *System* menu combined. The right side displays the contents of the menu.

As expected, by default, the screen focuses on the *Favourites* menu. It comes with a handy set of default favourite apps. Of course, it's up to the user to customise it to his own likes. You simply hover the mouse over an application icon and click the plus sign that appears to define it as one of your 'favourites'. In fact, during my tests I was able to include all the apps I required here so that I hardly required to navigate down the other menus.

The top panel remains with the standard system tray, populated with icons for wireless connectivity, Bluetooth, battery levels, etc. However, what seems like the task bar is actually a place for the title bar of the application you're currently working on. This is a good add-on which saves some essential screen space. But, how to access the other apps that are also open? Well, they're listed as small icons on the left the



▲ The default/favourites tab on UNR



▲ Accessing the Games menu



▲ Running Firefox; note the title bar fuse into the panel



▲ The background gets dimmed when an unmaximised window is open